ARTICLE 2 CORINTHIANS 4:10-12 8 NOV 2026 NORM REED

Death in Us, Life in You

We prefer our leaders to be a source of energy.

The modern expectation of ministry is that the person at the front of the room has a surplus of vitality. They cast the vision, they drive the programme, they generate the momentum. If the leader is exhausted, we assume something is wrong – that they have failed to manage their boundaries, or lost their passion, or slipped out of the centre of God's will.

Paul's arithmetic is different.

In 2 Corinthians 4 he sets out the daily, grinding reality of his work. He is carrying around in his body the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed.

> *So death is at work in us, but life in you.*

He does not say that his suffering produces his own spiritual growth. He says his dying is the mechanism for their living.

Two things in verse eleven keep this from becoming a theory. It is *for Jesus' sake*, and it happens *in our mortal flesh*. Not a technique for getting results out of suffering, and not a noble idea about sacrificial leadership. A particular man, in a body that was going to die, handed over for the sake of a particular Lord.

Watchman Nee worked this ground, and his argument was that the church has misunderstood how grace moves from one person to another. We think ministry is the transfer of information — one intact, unbroken person handing a good idea to someone else. Nee said ministry is the release of life, and that life cannot be released until the outer vessel is broken.

If you are going to hold the light you have to be the clay pot. But if the life is going to reach anyone, the pot has to crack. The outer man — our competence, our need to be the saviour, our natural resilience — has to give way. Absorbing the friction of ministry was not an unfortunate side-effect of Paul's work. It was the work.

In the Room

I see this in the justice system.

When you sit across the table from someone doing the slow work of rehabilitation, there are no quick fixes. Progress is fragile. Relapses happen. The anger and the red tape pile up, and if you stay in the room long enough you end up absorbing it.

A programme protects you from that. A programme has office hours. It lets you deliver a service and go home intact.

Presence costs you your margins.

When you choose presence you take the hit. You sit with the frustration, the setbacks, the unravelling of someone else's life, and you hold your

position, so that the person across the table has enough oxygen to take their next step. You absorb the death so they can have the life.

You cannot orchestrate this on a whiteboard. You cannot put it in a funding application. It happens quietly, in ones and twos, when a leader stops trying to fix the room and agrees to be broken for it.

Death in us. Life in you.

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.